

A group of passionate beer lovers has set up their own breweries, introducing craft beer to thirsty drinkers. While this is still a small market, it is forecast to grow at 108 per cent in volume terms



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Effingut, in 2015. It brews its various styles of beer across five breweries in India and is enjoyed in over 500 towns across 15 countries. Its signature taprooms in Bengaluru serve 20 kinds of beer on tap and introduce an experimental beer every week. Plans are on to set up a taproom in Delhi-NCR. “At present, we have eight flavours in the Bira 91 beer portfolio ranging from lagers to wheat beers to IPA. We recently launched RISE, India’s first premium rice strong lager, and expanded beyond beer with ‘House of Bira 91’, introducing the ‘Hill-station’ Hard Cider Ale and ‘Grizly’ Hard Seltzer Ale to appeal to a wider audience and drive growth in the premium beverage segment,” says Ankur Jain, CEO, B9 Beverages. Bira, which is backed by Sequoia Capital India, Sofina of Belgium and Kirin Holding of Japan, recently raised \$10 million from MUFG Bank.

Then there’s Simba, a passion project of cousins Ishwaraj and Prabhtej Singh Bhatia. Ishwaraj saw the launch of Cobra beer in the UK and thought there was a gap in the Indian market for craft beer. A brewery was set up at Durg in Chhattisgarh and Simba was born in 2016. Available in 15 states with a portfolio consisting of Wit, Light, Stout and Strong, it posted a turnover of ₹150 crore in FY22. Simba Stout is popular with beer enthusiasts as it is India’s first bottled stout. “We take pride in using local ingredients such as lemongrass, coriander seeds, coffee and orange” says Ishwaraj.

Then there is Kati Patang, the love affair of husband-wife duo Shantanu and Lata Upadhyay with beer. Shantanu, a consultant with Boston Consulting Group specialising in telecom and tech, and Lata, an advertising and research professional, gave

up their corporate careers to brew beer and launched Kati Patang in 2018. “One of the guys who started the craft beer revolution in the US, was also ex-BCG. We could see very clear analogies between what happened in the US in the ’80s and what was happening in India now,” says Shantanu, adding that beer works very well for Indian weather and wins hands down over wine since wine dehydrates. Kati Patang currently has four styles—Zesty Amber, Snappy Wheat, Saffron Lager and Bareilly Bold. All styles use local ingredients. For instance, the wheat beer has peppercorn and coriander along with ginger and turmeric, while the lager has subtle notes of saffron, and the light bodied Bareilly Bold has notes of spring flower Palash. The beer is available in Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Chandigarh and Goa.

Craft beer has taken the fancy of beer enthusiasts and there are several other brands in the market such as White Rhino, Maka Di, Bee Young, Eight Finger Eddie, Susegado, etc., offering beer lovers a variety of tipples. “In terms of demand we haven’t even scratched the surface. There is a willingness to pay a premium for a better quality product,” says Shantanu.

As the mercury rises and the sun shines brighter, demand for beer will only increase. After all, there’s no better way to enjoy the summer than grabbing a cold one. As they say, it’s always beer ‘o’ clock somewhere. **BT**

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